

HKLMSAM Key

For most users, this key seems to be empty (unless they are granted access by administrators of the local system or administrators of domains managing the local system). It's used to refer to all "Security and Accounts Management" (SAM) databases for all domains into which the local system has been administratively authorised or configured (including the running system's local domain, which has a subkey named "SAM" in its SAM database; additional subkeys will be created as needed, one for each supplementary domain).

Each SAM database contains all built-in accounts (mostly group aliases) and configured accounts (users, groups and their aliases, including guest accounts and administrator accounts) created and configured on the respective domain, for each account in that domain, it notably contains the user name which can be used to log on that domain, the internal unique user identifier in the domain, their cryptographically hashed password on that domain, the location of storage of their user registry hive, various status flags (for example if the account can be enumerated and be visible in the logon prompt screen), and the list of domains (including the local domain) into which the account was configured.

HKLMSECURITY Key

This key is linked to the Security database of the domain into which the current user is logged on (if the user is logged on the local system domain, this key will be linked to the registry hive stored by the local machine and managed by local system administrators or by the builtin "System" account and Windows installers). It is usually empty for most users (unless they are granted access by users with administrative privileges). The kernel will utilise it to read and enforce the security policy that applies to the current user and all of their programmes and operations. It also has a "SAM" subkey that is dynamically linked to the domain's SAM database, where the current user is logged on.

HKLMSYSTEM Key

Users with administrative access on the local system are usually the only ones who may write to this key. It contains data for the secure random number generator (RNG), a list of currently mounted devices with a file system, several numbered "HKLMSYSTEMControl Sets" containing alternative configurations for system hardware drivers and services running